
Understanding Stress in the Body

Why your shoulders are at your ears by 3 PM
even when nothing's wrong

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Continuity Member Edition — Month 1

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Published by Healing Hands By Nate

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Introduction

A BETWEEN-SESSIONS MODULE ON THE PART OF stress that nobody warned you about — the part that lives in your tissue.

If you've ever wondered why your shoulders are up around your ears by 3 PM even though nothing particularly stressful happened — this is why.

Most people talk about stress like it's an emotion. Something you feel. Something happening "in your head." That framing isn't wrong, but it's incomplete in a way that costs you.

Stress is a physical state. Your body braces. Your breathing shallows. Your muscles lock. Your nervous system shifts into a different mode of operation. All of that is happening whether you consciously feel "stressed" or not.

Once you understand that, a lot of mysterious body symptoms start making sense. The neck tension that doesn't track to anything. The jaw that's sore in the morning. The lower back that's tight on Tuesday for no reason. The shoulders that creep up without you noticing.

These aren't random. They're your body's stress fingerprints, showing up in the same predictable places over and over.

This module is about reading those fingerprints.

CHAPTER 1

Stress isn't an emotion — it's a physical state

WHEN YOUR NERVOUS SYSTEM PERCEIVES A threat — real, imagined, social, financial, anything — it activates a cascade of physical responses. Your body shifts into what biologists call sympathetic nervous system mode. Fight or flight.

What's actually happening in your tissue during this shift:

- **Muscles brace.** The big “fight or run” muscles tighten in preparation for sudden action.
- **Breathing changes.** Slow, deep diaphragmatic breaths give way to shallow, upper-chest breathing that delivers oxygen faster but less efficiently.
- **Heart rate increases.** Blood flow shifts toward muscles and away from digestion.
- **Pupils dilate.** Visual field sharpens, focus narrows.
- **Stress hormones release.** Cortisol and adrenaline cascade through your system.

- **Pain threshold rises.** Your nervous system gets less reactive to small discomforts so you can focus on the threat.

This is great if there's an actual threat — a car swerving toward you, an animal in the dark, a sudden danger. The system works exactly as designed.

The problem is that modern life keeps your nervous system in this state for hours and days at a time, not minutes. Work pressure. Financial worry. Family dynamics. The general hum of a busy life. Your nervous system doesn't distinguish between "I'm being chased" and "I'm overwhelmed by my inbox." Both trigger the same physical cascade.

When that cascade runs for hours every day, weeks turning into months turning into years, your body adapts. The bracing becomes baseline. The shallow breathing becomes default. The tight shoulders become "just how my shoulders are."

That's chronic stress in the body. And it's measurable, observable, and addressable.

CHAPTER 2

The top 3 places stress hides

EVERY BODY IS UNIQUE, BUT AFTER 12+ YEARS on the table, I can tell you the three places I find chronic stress most often. If you carry tension, it's almost certainly showing up in one or more of these:

The jaw

This is the most-missed one. The jaw is the original “holding muscle” — humans evolved with strong jaw muscles for chewing tough food and biting in fights. When the nervous system goes into bracing mode, the jaw clenches. Almost universally.

Most people clench without knowing it. They have no conscious awareness of jaw tension during the day. Then they notice their teeth touching when they aren't chewing. They notice a soreness in the muscle below their cheekbone. They notice headaches at the temples or behind the eyes.

All of that is stress in the jaw. Not “TMJ” as a separate condition — TMJ symptoms are usually the downstream signal that the jaw has been bracing for too long.

The shoulders

The shoulders pull up toward the ears in a stress response. It's a protective reflex — bringing the shoulders up shortens the distance between head and torso, conceptually shielding the vulnerable neck.

In a brief stress event, the shoulders return to their resting position once the event passes. In chronic stress, they don't. They stay slightly elevated all day, every day, until that elevated position becomes the new baseline.

You can usually catch this by checking yourself at 3 PM on a weekday. Where are your shoulders? Most people, when they check, find their shoulders at least an inch higher than their natural resting position. Many find them significantly higher.

That's not posture. That's stress.

The low back

This is the third predictable spot. The deep stabilizers in the low back — particularly the quadratus lumborum and the psoas (which is also a hip flexor, also a stress muscle) — brace under chronic stress.

The result is the low-back tension that doesn't track to any specific physical activity. The back is "tight" but you didn't lift anything heavy. The back is "stiff" but you've been sitting normally. This is stress storage.

The body is bracing for something that's not actually coming.

Why these three spots specifically? They're the load-bearing connection points of the upper body, the literal core of postural support, and the body's deepest stress-response muscles. They take the load because that's what they're built for. Unfortunately, "built to handle some load" doesn't mean "built to handle all of it, all the time."

CHAPTER 3

Acute stress versus chronic stress

THERE'S A CRITICAL DISTINCTION HERE THAT most people miss.

Acute stress is the body's appropriate response to a real, present threat or challenge. It's short-term, high-intensity, and beneficial when used correctly. Acute stress sharpens focus, primes muscles, mobilizes energy. After the threat passes, the system returns to baseline.

Chronic stress is the body operating in stress-response mode continuously, without return to baseline. The system never gets to recover. The bracing never releases. The breathing never restores. The cortisol stays elevated.

Acute stress: a tool. Chronic stress: a tax.

The body absolutely can handle acute stress — that's what it's designed for. What it cannot handle indefinitely is chronic stress without recovery. The cumulative wear on tissue, on the nervous system, on metabolism, is real and measurable.

For most clients I work with, the issue isn't that they have stress. Everyone has stress. The issue is

that they never give their body permission to fully come out of the stress response. The cumulative load keeps building.

The fix isn't eliminating stress (impossible). The fix is learning to read the bracing patterns AND interrupting them deliberately, multiple times a day.

CHAPTER 4

The 60-second body scan

THIS IS YOUR TOOL FOR THE MONTH. THE simplest stress-detection technique I know, and one of the most useful.

Once a day, every day, do this 60-second scan. Sitting or standing. Eyes open or closed. Doesn't matter.

Move your attention slowly down your body, station by station. At each station, just notice:

- 1. Jaw** — Are my teeth touching? Is my tongue pressed against the roof of my mouth or the back of my teeth?
- 2. Forehead** — Am I furrowing? Tension behind my eyes?
- 3. Neck** — Is my chin slightly tucked? Is my neck stiff?
- 4. Shoulders** — Are they up toward my ears? Hunched forward?
- 5. Chest** — Is my breath shallow? Am I holding my breath?
- 6. Hands** — Are my fists clenched? Fingers tight?

- 7. Stomach** — Am I tight in the belly? Holding tension there?
- 8. Hips** — Is my low back tight? Hips clenched?
- 9. Legs** — Am I tensing my thighs? Toes curled?

This takes 60 seconds once you've done it a few times. You don't have to fix anything you find. The point of the scan is awareness, not correction.

But here's what you'll discover: the act of noticing tension is often enough to release it. You'll find your jaw clenched, and just by noticing it, it'll drop. You'll find your shoulders up, and they'll fall. The body, when its bracing is brought into conscious awareness, often releases it automatically.

That's the magic of the scan. It's not a treatment. It's a recognition. The recognition is most of the work.

CHAPTER 5

The assignment for this month

JUST NOTICE.

That's it. That's the whole assignment.

For the next 30 days, do the 60-second body scan twice a day. Once in the morning. Once mid-afternoon. Pick fixed times if you need to — alongside your coffee, after lunch, whenever fits.

Don't try to fix anything you find. Don't add stretches yet. Don't change your behavior yet. Just notice where you're holding stress, and let that awareness itself be the work.

Within two weeks, most people doing this consistently start noticing patterns. "I always clench my jaw when I'm on Zoom calls." "My shoulders go up around my mom." "My low back tightens every Tuesday." That data is gold. You can't fix patterns you can't see.

Once the patterns are visible to you, the rest of the year's modules give you the tools to address them.

CHAPTER 6

What to expect

BY THE END OF JANUARY WITH CONSISTENT DAILY scans:

- You'll know your three personal high-stress body areas
- You'll catch yourself bracing throughout the day
- Small releases will start happening automatically when you notice
- Your awareness of your own body will be measurably sharper
- The patterns of when and where you stress will become clear

This isn't dramatic. It's small, daily, observational. But it's the foundation everything else builds on. You can't release tension you don't know you're holding.

CHAPTER 7

When to come see me

IF YOUR SCANS ARE REVEALING CHRONIC TENSION in one or two areas that you can't seem to release on your own, that's the right time to book a session. We'll work the area together, and I'll show you exactly what your bracing pattern feels like from the outside so you can recognize it from the inside.

The combination of self-awareness practice (the scans) plus targeted bodywork is what produces the biggest, most durable releases.

CHAPTER 8

Closing

START NOTICING WHERE YOU HOLD IT. THAT'S the whole assignment this month. Just notice.

Most people skip January because the goals feel small. They want to lift the heavy weight first. They want to fix the tight back, release the locked jaw, drop the chronic shoulder tension. All of that is downstream of the foundational work this month: learning to notice.

You cannot release what you can't see. The scan is how you start seeing.

Two minutes a day. Two times. That's the deal.

The companion workbook has a structured 7-day awareness tracker, a stress pattern self-assessment, and three reflection prompts to help you map your own body's stress signature.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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